

Brandon eventually hit his FI number. Although he was still working, he'd already become a happier person. Achieving FI didn't change anything. He said, "I've been planning for this and putting off happiness until I hit this goal and now I hit it, and it's like . . . nothing is different." Looking back, it was obvious. Having an extra dollar in your bank account doesn't magically change things. It's a powerful lesson to heed as we go about building happier lives on the journey to FI.

Embrace Your Mistakes

A lot of my unhappiness on the path to FI came as a result of comparing myself to others in the FI community. While the stories in this book can be inspirational, they can also lead you to play "what if?" while dwelling on past mistakes. In my case, I did most of the things others on more optimal paths were doing, often as well or better than they did. At the same time, my wife and I made massive investing and tax-planning mistakes. We blindly trusted an advisor who put his interests ahead of our own, causing us to pay unnecessary fees and taxes that lengthened the journey to FI by years. I was bitter and regretful that I hadn't taken the time to educate myself sooner.